Financing Main Street America: How a National Place-Based Model Pays for Its Work

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Abstract

Originating in 1977 as a National Trust for Historic Preservation pilot in three small Midwestern downtowns, Main Street America has grown into a national network of more than 1,200 designated commercial districts, organized through 41 state coordinating programs and a small number of city-coordinated variants. The network reports cumulative reinvestment of $107.6 billion since 1980 (Main Street America 2025). This paper studies how Main Street America funds its work. The organization deploys very little capital from its own balance sheet. Instead, it operates as an intermediary that aggregates small projects, packages them, and connects them to the financing tools already available in the economic-development toolkit: Community Development Block Grants, federal and state historic tax credits (HTC), Small Business Administration loans, business improvement district assessments, tax increment financing, philanthropic grants, and private equity. This paper spotlights Main Street America at the national coordinating level, then zooms in on two local cases. Pennsylvania, working through the $20 million Main Street Matters initiative launched in 2024, illustrates a state-coordinated three-layer architecture, with Main Street Gettysburg as the local example. Boston, through the country's first citywide Main Streets program (1995), illustrates a city-coordinated two-layer architecture, with Roslindale Village Main Street as the local example.

1. Main Street America

1.1 Origins

The Main Street model grew from the wave of downtown decline that hit American small towns in the 1960s and 1970s. By the mid-1970s, mall construction and the relocation of retail to suburban arterials had emptied historic main streets of their anchor tenants, and the buildings that had defined those downtowns were vacant, deteriorating, or threatened with demolition. In 1977, the National Trust for Historic Preservation responded with the Main Street Project, a three-year demonstration in three Midwestern towns: Galesburg, Illinois; Madison, Indiana; and Hot Springs, South Dakota (Main Street America n.d.a). The pilot was designed to test whether historic preservation could be paired with economic development to address both the physical and commercial decline of small downtowns. The pilot worked. In 1980, the National Trust established the National Main Street Center to scale the approach, and over the next three decades, the model spread to forty-plus state coordinating programs, thousands of designated districts, and (by 2013) a spin-out into Main Street America as an independent nonprofit (Main Street America n.d.a). As of 2025, the network includes 1,172 designated communities, 800 of which hold the top “Accredited” status under Main Street America's evaluation framework (Main Street America 2025).

1.2 The Four-Point Approach

Main Street America's working method uses a Four-Point Approach, which also serves as the standard for evaluating and certifying members. They are:

- **Economic Vitality** focuses on strengthening the local business base: recruiting new businesses, supporting entrepreneurs, helping existing shops expand, and connecting district businesses with capital.
- **Design** covers the physical environment: facades, signage, accessibility, streetscapes, lighting, and the preservation of historic building stock.
- **Promotion** covers marketing and image-building: events, branding, social media, and tourism outreach.
- **Organization** covers the institutional capacity that holds the other three points together: staff, volunteers, board governance, fundraising, and partnerships.

The four points are operational, not financial. Each local district organizes its work under these four interrelated elements. They tell a local Main Street nonprofit what to do; they do not tell it where to find the money to do the work. Funding is layered on top of the method, which is the subject of Section 2.

1.3 Scale and Self-Reported Impact

Main Street America's most recent annual report places the network's collective 2024 outcomes at $5.68 billion in reinvestment, 35,162 net new jobs, 6,630 net new businesses, 10,556 buildings rehabilitated, and 1.66 million volunteer hours mobilized, for a reported return of $18.03 in local investment per dollar spent by Main Street programs (Main Street America 2025). Cumulatively, since 1980, the network reports $107.62 billion in reinvestment, 175,323 new businesses, 782,059 new jobs, and 335,675 buildings rehabilitated.

I would like to highlight that the above numbers are self-reported. The most rigorous independent assessment to date, by economist Andrew Van Leuven (2021), found significant downtown jobs and business effects in Iowa Main Street communities yet no significant overall effects in Michigan, Ohio, or Wisconsin, and concluded that the model's benefits “are not generalizable across states” but rather depend heavily on local implementation and context. Convergent Nonprofit Solutions, a fundraising consultancy that works with Main Street programs nationally, frames the same finding in operational language: “outcomes aren't automatic” and depend on sustained funding alignment (Convergent Nonprofit Solutions n.d.). That being said, this paper does not debate the impact results. Our focus is to understand how main street revitalization is funded.

2. How Main Street America Finances Its Work

2.1 Capital Stacking, Not Lending

First off, it is important to reiterate that Main Street America does not lend. It is not a bank, a Community Development Financial Institution, or a real-estate investment vehicle. At the national level, Main Street America holds essentially no capital on its balance sheet intended for deployment into local projects. Its 2025 consolidated operating revenue was $17.7 million, almost all of which funded the organization's own staff, federal lobbying, training, accreditation, and convening activities (Main Street America 2025). Local Main Street nonprofits operate at a much smaller scale still. Roslindale Village Main Street, for example, reported total revenue of $521,227 in FY2023 and made $73,319 in pass-through grants to district businesses (ProPublica n.d.a). At every level of the network, the dollars on the organization's balance sheet alone are too small to fuel meaningful redevelopment.

The financing problem Main Street America addresses is two-sided. On one side, the small businesses and property owners who actually need capital (a shop owner trying to renovate a 1920s storefront, a couple opening a café in a vacant building) rarely have the staff, time, or technical skill to navigate the eight or ten different funding programs that, in combination, could make their project pencil. They do not have a grant writer or a tax credit consultant on payroll. On the other side, the major funders who hold the capital they need (banks, federal agencies, state historic preservation offices, large foundations) prefer fewer, larger deals to many small ones. The transaction costs of underwriting a $50,000 small-business loan are not significantly lower than those of underwriting a $5 million commercial loan, but the revenue is. Few institutional funders are willing to staff up to do hundreds of tiny deals. The result is a capital-allocation gap: capital exists, demand exists, but the two cannot meet without an intermediary.

What Main Street America does is to act as that intermediary. The local main street coordinating organizations perform two functions that, taken together, constitute the program's financing of main street programs. First, it acts as a consultant to small businesses and property owners in its districts, helping them identify which programs they qualify for, walking them through the application process, and assembling the supporting documentation needed to access funding. Second, it acts as an aggregator on the funder side, packaging many small projects into a single pipeline that a federal agency, a state grant program, or a private foundation can underwrite as a coherent block. Together, these functions are how Main Street America practices capital stacking. The technique itself, well-established in economic-development finance, is to layer multiple sources of capital with different terms, priorities, and underwriting criteria into a single project's financing structure. What is distinctive about Main Street America's application of it is the scale: the model brings capital stacking to projects too small or too marginal for any one institutional funder to underwrite alone. This is what Karl Seidman calls layered economic development finance (Seidman 2004, chs. 14–15). The role is one of project facilitation rather than capital provision. Main Street America packages deals; it does not fund them.

2.2 The Three-Tier Organizational Architecture

Capital stacking happens at three levels of the Main Street network, each of which raises and spends money differently.

The national tier. Main Street America, headquartered in Chicago, generates revenue largely through grants and contributions, contracts (often with state programs), membership dues from designated communities, conference and event revenue, and earned income from its insurance affiliate, Main Street Insurance Services. Its FY2025 consolidated revenue of $17.7 million had a 12 percent general and administrative expense ratio, which is unusually efficient for a national membership nonprofit (Main Street America 2025).

The state or city tier. In most states, this tier is a state agency, typically housed in the state's commerce, community/economic development, or historic preservation department. Forty-one states currently operate one. State coordinators are funded primarily by state legislative appropriations, supplemented by federal pass-through dollars (especially CDBG) and, in some states, by contracts with the state's nonprofit Main Street affiliate. Pennsylvania, for example, recently created a $20 million Main Street Matters appropriation for FY24 through FY26 (Pennsylvania DCED 2024). Virginia raised its state Main Street appropriation from $0.5 million to $2.1 million in the FY26 budget (Virginia LIS 2025). A small number of cities run their own citywide Main Streets systems instead of relying on the state. Since 1995, Boston has been the canonical example. The city tier raises money differently than the state tier: it draws on city general fund dollars, on the city's CDBG entitlement (in cities like Boston that receive a direct HUD grant rather than a state pass-through), and on city-affiliated foundation infrastructure. Both forms of coordinator perform a similar function: they manage local designations, distribute grant funding, deliver technical assistance, and serve as the institutional bridge between the local nonprofit and the funders above it.

The local tier. Local Main Street programs are the front-line organizations that actually do the work in each district. Most are independent 501(c)(3) nonprofits; a smaller number are city departments. They run lean. A typical local Main Street program has fewer than five paid staff, supplemented by a board of directors and a network of volunteer committee members organized around the four points. Their revenue mix includes municipal operating support, foundation and community-foundation grants, business sponsorships, member dues, signature event income, and (less often) program-service revenue from contracts with the city or county. As Sections 3 and 4 will show, the precise mix of these sources varies sharply depending on which kind of coordinator sits above the local district.

2.3 The Funding Sources Main Street Districts Actually Draw On

A typical Main Street capital stack draws from four buckets, each of which contributes a different kind of dollar to the corridor.

Federal sources. The Community Development Block Grant program is the single most consistent federal channel into Main Street districts. In CDBG entitlement cities like Boston, the city receives an annual formula grant directly from HUD and decides how to allocate it across eligible activities, which include Main Street facade and infrastructure programs (Main Street America n.d.b). In smaller communities, CDBG flows through a state pass-through. The federal Historic Tax Credit, which provides a 20 percent credit against rehabilitation costs for income-producing historic buildings, is the second pillar. Most substantial Main Street rehab projects draw on it. Beyond those two, Main Street districts variously tap two distinct Small Business Administration tools: the microloan program, which channels loans of up to $50,000 to district businesses through nonprofit intermediaries, and the 7(a) loan guarantee program, which uses the federal balance sheet to backstop larger commercial loans made by private lenders. Districts also draw on HUD Community Project Funding earmarks (the modern descendant of the earmark process, which has produced specific recent awards like the Gettysburg Welcome Center discussed in Section 3.5), Economic Development Administration placemaking grants, and, where the district is adjacent to a federal site, National Park Service partnerships such as Preserve America.

State sources. The headline state source is the state Main Street appropriation itself, where one exists. Pennsylvania's Main Street Matters program is the most recently capitalized example, providing competitive grants of up to $225,000 per designated community plus statewide technical assistance (Pennsylvania DCED 2024). State historic tax credits, which can typically be stacked on top of the federal version, are the second major channel. Pennsylvania's state HTC awarded $5 million across 21 projects in the FY23–24 round (Pennsylvania Historic Preservation 2024). Massachusetts also operates a state HTC, administered by the Massachusetts Historical Commission, which the Roslindale Substation project drew on for an estimated $700,000 (Section 4.5). State Downtown Initiative grant programs, such as Massachusetts's $550,000-$600,000 annual Massachusetts Downtown Initiative (MDI) rounds, provide smaller technical assistance and project grants.

Municipal sources. City general-fund operating support is the most flexible municipal dollar. CDBG entitlement, for cities that receive it directly from HUD, is the largest. Beyond those two, cities can layer in ARPA allocations (which have largely sunset by 2026), business improvement district assessments, tax increment financing for streetscape and infrastructure work, and city-administered facade or signage programs.

Philanthropic and private sources. Community foundations are the most reliable philanthropic partners for local Main Street programs, both because they are typically place-based and because they tend to support exactly the kind of small-grants programming that Main Street districts deliver. The Adams County Community Foundation in Pennsylvania, for example, contributed $40,000 to Main Street Gettysburg in 2023 across two grants: a $20,000 Forward Fund award and a $20,000 Challenge Grant, both toward the Gettysburg Welcome Center (Main Street Gettysburg 2025b). Corporate sponsorships, business member dues, and signature event revenue make up the private layer; Roslindale Village Main Street, for example, lists tiered sponsorships starting at $5,000 (Roslindale Village Main Street n.d.b).

One observation regarding reliability is noteworthy before moving on. The most reliable source within a Main Street capital stack varies by jurisdiction. For the conventional state-coordinated Main Street program in a small town, the most stable annual revenue is usually the state Main Street appropriation (where one exists) plus borough or county in-kind support, both of which arrive on predictable cycles. For the city-coordinated variant operating in a CDBG entitlement city like Boston, the equivalent is the city's general-fund operating support plus its CDBG allocation, because both flow predictably from the same municipal department. The federal layer matters, but in most cases, it is not the foundation of the capital stack. The foundation is local.

3. The Pennsylvania Model: Main Street Gettysburg

Pennsylvania is one of the 41 state-coordinated Main Street programs in the national network, and as of 2024, it operates one of the most generously funded state-level Main Street initiatives in the country. The Pennsylvania architecture has three layers. At the top, the Pennsylvania Department of Community and Economic Development (DCED) administers the state Main Street program through its Center for Local Government Services. In the middle, the Pennsylvania Downtown Center (PDC), a nonprofit Main Street America affiliate, has served as the state's coordinator under contract for 24 years, delivering training, accreditation support, and technical assistance to designated districts (Pennsylvania Downtown Center n.d.). At the bottom, local implementing entities (typically independent 501(c)(3) nonprofits) carry out the four-point work in each designated downtown. Main Street Gettysburg is the local example used here.

3.1 Pennsylvania's Main Street Program Structure

Pennsylvania has run a state Main Street program through DCED since the 1980s, but for most of its history, the program operated at a relatively modest scale, supported by small recurring state appropriations. Its funding profile changed substantially in 2024, when the Shapiro Administration announced the Main Street Matters initiative, a $20 million state appropriation spanning FY24 through FY26, structured as competitive grants of up to $225,000 per designated community, plus statewide technical assistance (Pennsylvania DCED 2024). The new appropriation is the largest dedicated state Main Street funding commitment Pennsylvania has made in decades. The Shapiro Administration described the program as a tool to "support downtown revitalization and small business growth in communities across the Commonwealth," and the funding round prioritized communities that could demonstrate organizational capacity and a clear five-year strategic plan. The program is fresh enough that its full long-term effects are not yet visible in the network's outcome data, which is why the case is useful for a finance paper: it captures a state Main Street program at the moment of its largest recent recapitalization.

3.2 Main Street Gettysburg

Main Street Gettysburg, Inc. is an independent 501(c)(3) historic-downtown revitalization nonprofit that achieved 2025 Accredited status under Main Street America's national evaluation framework, the network's top tier (Borough of Gettysburg 2025). Its mission, as described in its public filings, is "to encourage the preservation and revitalization of historic Gettysburg, Pennsylvania, for the benefit of its citizens, businesses and visitors, via co-op loan programs, economic development, various grant programs, and beautification projects" (ProPublica n.d.b). It operates alongside the Borough of Gettysburg's government rather than within it, and it sits within a larger local economic-development ecosystem that includes Destination Gettysburg (the regional tourism marketing organization, which receives 75 percent of the Adams County hotel tax) and the Adams County Economic Development Corporation.

3.3 The District

Downtown Gettysburg is centered on Lincoln Square, with the surrounding blocks of Baltimore, Carlisle, Chambersburg, and York Streets defining the historic commercial core. The borough's population is 8,254 according to the most recent ACS five-year estimates, with a median household income of $54,365 and a median age of 22.3 (US Census Bureau 2024a). The young median age reflects Gettysburg College's enrollment of approximately 2,000 students. The poverty rate is 14.1 percent. Adams County, the county in which Gettysburg sits, has a population of approximately 106,000 and a median household income of $84,092, meaning the borough is meaningfully poorer than its surrounding county. Building stock in the downtown is largely 19th-century brick commercial, much of it National Register-eligible, which is both a heritage asset and a rehab cost driver.

The economic backdrop matters: Gettysburg's downtown sits inside a heritage-tourism economy of substantial scale. Gettysburg National Military Park drew 742,000 visitors in 2023 and contributed $88.5 million to the local economy (National Park Service 2024). Adams County's visitor economy reached $809.2 million in spending in 2024, supporting 5,101 jobs (Destination Gettysburg 2025). Heritage tourism is the economic substrate that makes the building stock viable; without it, the downtown's many National Register-eligible buildings would be much harder to finance.

3.4 Main Street Gettysburg's Capital Stack

Main Street Gettysburg's funding profile, walked through from largest and most stable to smallest and most discretionary, is shown in Exhibit A. The state of Pennsylvania is the primary public funder. Main Street Gettysburg holds the Main Street Matters designation, which makes it eligible for grants of up to $225,000 plus statewide technical assistance. PA DCED has also awarded MSG a $50,000 Keystone Community Grant under the Keystone Communities Program, which funds the Facade Improvement Program (reimbursement grants of up to $5,000 per property with a dollar-for-dollar local match) (Borough of Gettysburg n.d.a). The Pennsylvania Historic Preservation Tax Credit, awarded to 21 projects totaling $5 million in the FY23–24 round, is a third state channel for property-level rehab work in the corridor. Federal sources include the Federal Historic Tax Credit on the corridor's many National Register buildings and a recent HUD Community Project Funding earmark of $1,272,436 for the Gettysburg Welcome Center, signed into law on March 9, 2024 (Borough of Gettysburg 2024). Borough and county sources are smaller. The Borough of Gettysburg's FY26 general fund is $7.5 million, and while the borough does not show a documented direct line item to Main Street Gettysburg, it provides in-kind staff support, infrastructure investment, and the local match commitments required by most state grants. Adams County's hotel tax, as noted, flows mostly to Destination Gettysburg rather than to Main Street Gettysburg. Philanthropic support is led by the Adams County Community Foundation, which has funded Main Street Gettysburg with a $10,000 Forward Fund award (Gettysburg Connection n.d.b). Earned and private revenue includes business member dues, signature events such as the annual Gettysburg Christmas Festival and GettysFest, and corporate sponsorships from heritage-tourism businesses.

3.5 Project Highlight: The Gettysburg Welcome Center

A clean illustration of how Main Street Gettysburg's capital stack works at the project level is the Gettysburg Welcome Center, currently under construction with a 2026 completion target timed to America's 250th anniversary. The project sits at the southwest corner of Lincoln Square on the site of a previously demolished historic property and will house visitor information services, a transportation interface, public restrooms, and ADA-accessible facilities. Total documented construction funding for the project is $1,612,436 (Main Street Gettysburg 2025b).

The federal layer is the largest single line by a wide margin. A HUD Community Project Funding award of $1,272,436 was appropriated in the FY24 federal omnibus signed by President Biden on March 9, 2024, with bipartisan sponsorship from Senators Bob Casey and John Fetterman and Representative John Joyce (Borough of Gettysburg 2024). That one line covers approximately 79 percent of the construction budget. A capital ask of this size is well beyond what borough cash and corridor fundraising could have assembled on their own, which is precisely why it required a federal political channel rather than a programmatic one to close.

The remaining 21 percent, $340,000, was assembled across three documented local commitments. The largest is a $300,000 line in the Borough of Gettysburg's FY2025 Capital

Improvement Plan, which represents borough capital reserve and general fund money formally allocated to the project. The other $40,000 came earlier, from two Adams County Community Foundation awards in 2023: a $20,000 ACCF Forward Fund grant and a $20,000 ACCF Challenge Grant. Both ACCF grants predate the federal appropriation and were the early seed money that allowed Main Street Gettysburg to demonstrate local support for the project before larger commitments came in.

The sequencing is itself the lesson. The philanthropic dollars came first (ACCF, 2023), the federal dollars second (HUD CPF, 2024), and the borough's largest commitment third (Capital Improvement Plan, 2025). Each stage of the stack made the next one possible. The ACCF awards gave Main Street Gettysburg a credible local commitment to cite when it approached congressional offices for federal appropriations. The federal appropriation, in turn, gave the borough a defensible reason to commit $300,000 from its capital plan. Without the early $40,000 in philanthropic seed money, neither of the larger commitments would have arrived in the same form. Main Street Gettysburg's intermediary role spanned all three: it built the case to ACCF for the seed grants, to the three congressional offices that sponsored the federal appropriation, and to the borough that the federal commitment justified a corresponding capital plan line. The Welcome Center is, in microcosm, what the four-point method looks like when the Organization point sits behind a multi-stage federal-anchored capital ask.

4. The Boston Model: Roslindale Village Main Street

Boston is the canonical example of the city-coordinated Main Streets variant. When the National Trust for Historic Preservation began looking, in the early 1990s, for ways to adapt the small-town Main Street method to dense urban neighborhoods, Boston was the first city to adopt the model at scale. Mayor Thomas Menino launched Boston Main Streets in 1995, with an initial cohort of 10 districts; the program expanded to 20 districts over the following decade and remains the largest citywide Main Streets system in the country (City of Boston 2015). The Boston architecture has two layers above the local district. At the top, the Mayor's Office of Economic Opportunity and Inclusion (OEOI), reorganized from the earlier Office of Economic Development in 2022, administers the program from inside city government. In the middle, the Boston Main Streets Foundation, a city-affiliated 501(c)(3) chartered in 2005, provides financial and strategic-level support across all 20 districts. At the bottom, independent local 501(c)(3) Main Street nonprofits carry out the four-point work in each district. Roslindale Village Main Street is the local example used here.

4.1 Boston's Main Streets Program Structure

The City of Boston funds Boston Main Streets at approximately $1.5 million annually (most recent confirmable figure), assembled from city general-fund operating support, the city's CDBG entitlement allocation from HUD, and (during 2021–2024) ARPA pass-through dollars. The program funds a portion of each local Main Street nonprofit's operating budget, supplemented by program-level grants for facade work and small-business support. The Boston Main Streets Foundation, chartered in 2005, raises additional private and philanthropic dollars beyond the city's annual allocation and distributes them through a competitive proposal process across the 20 districts. The 20th-anniversary self-assessment of the program (2015) reported aggregate metrics from 1995 to 2015 of more than 1,390 new businesses, 8,170 new jobs, and 373,680 volunteer hours mobilized across all districts (City of Boston 2015). For the present paper, the structurally important feature is that the coordinating layer is municipal: the city, not the state, is the primary public funder of the Roslindale Village Main Street nonprofit.

4.2 Roslindale Village Main Street as Organization

Roslindale Village Main Street (RVMS), founded in 1985, predates Boston's citywide Main Streets program by a decade. It served as a working demonstration of the Main Street approach before the model was expanded citywide. RVMS was established with the support of then-City Councilor Thomas M. Menino and the National Trust for Historic Preservation through its National Main Street Center, becoming one of the first urban Main Street programs in the country (Roslindale Village Main Street n.d.c). Within its first three years, it generated 33 façade improvements, 43 commercial building rehabilitations, 29 net new businesses, 132 net new jobs, and over $5 million in private investment, evidence that the model could work in dense urban neighborhoods, not just small-town historic downtowns. After Menino became mayor in 1993, those Roslindale results helped him persuade the National Trust to expand the model citywide. The Boston Main Streets program was announced at the National Preservation Conference in October 1994 and formally launched in 1995 with ten designated districts (Menino 1995; Main Street America 2023). Its organizational form is functionally identical to Main Street Gettysburg's: independent local nonprofit, board governance, and four-point committee structure. Everything that differs between the two cases sits above the local nonprofit in the network hierarchy.

4.3 The District

The Roslindale Village commercial corridor is anchored at the intersection of Washington Street, Belgrade Avenue, Birch Street, and South Street, a place known locally as Roslindale Square. The district is a ten-minute neighborhood, walkable in five minutes from end to end, and served by the MBTA's Needham Line commuter rail station and several bus routes that connect to the Forest Hills Orange Line station, roughly a mile away. The corridor includes approximately 70 storefronts. ZIP code 02131, which encompasses the corridor and surrounding residential blocks, has a population of 30,544, a median household income of $111,006, a median home value of $634,200, and a poverty rate of 9.4 percent (US Census Bureau 2024b). The neighborhood has gentrified meaningfully since 2010, a fact relevant to Section 5's discussion of equity tensions in the model. The district's building stock is a mix of late-19th- and early-20th-century commercial structures, with some historic value (the Substation, discussed below, is on the National Register) but no heritage-tourism economy comparable to Gettysburg's.

4.4 RVMS's Capital Stack

Before walking through the specific funding sources that support RVMS's work, it is worth establishing the scale of the nonprofit's balance sheet. RVMS's FY2024 Form 990, the most recent available, reports total revenue of $456,673 and total expenses of $424,112, with five paid staff, 15 volunteers, and an 18-member board running the four-point work (ProPublica n.d.a). Executive Director Emma Blaxter's compensation was $82,716 in FY2024. The organization made no pass-through grants to district businesses in FY2024, after making $73,319 in such grants the prior year. The capital stack that follows is therefore the answer to a specific question: how does a local nonprofit operating on roughly half a million dollars a year, which writes essentially no checks of its own to corridor businesses, mobilize the public, philanthropic, and private dollars that make corridor revitalization possible?

That stack, walked through in the same order used for Main Street Gettysburg in Section 3.4 and shown in Exhibit B, begins with the largest single public source: the City of Boston, chiefly through OEOI's Main Streets program funding. CDBG entitlement, drawn down annually by the City under its Consolidated Plan with HUD, is layered on top of the general-fund allocation and, at the program level rather than the line-item level, supports facade and small-business activity in each district. ReStore Boston, a city-administered facade grant program, has historically been a recurring source of project-level dollars in the corridor. State sources are modest. The Massachusetts Downtown Initiative awarded $550,000 across 22 projects in FY24 and $600,000 across 20 projects in FY25, with no Roslindale-specific award identified in the most recent rounds, a pattern consistent with MDI's typical small-town focus. The Massachusetts state Historic Tax Credit, administered by the Massachusetts Historical Commission, has been important at the project level: the Substation, a project we highlight in the next section, drew an estimated $700,000 from this source. Federal sources include the Federal Historic Tax Credit on rehabilitated buildings (the Substation drew $569,085 from this layer) and SBA-backed microlending through partner CDFIs such as LISC Boston, the Boston Impact Initiative, and Mill Cities Community Investments. Philanthropic support comes from the Boston Foundation, the Hyams Foundation, the Klarman Family Foundation, and several local family foundations. Corporate and earned sources include sponsorships from regional businesses (Market Basket, Bain Capital, and others appear on the public sponsor list at the $5,000 “Rozzie Square Sponsor” tier and above), business member dues, and revenue from signature events, including Roslindale Open Studios, Spring Stroll, and Wicked Local Beer Garden (Roslindale Village Main Street n.d.b).

The organizational picture that emerges is consistent with the Section 2.1 framing: RVMS itself deploys very little capital, and the substantial corridor-level capital flows that revitalize Roslindale Village happen through partners (developers, CDFIs, the Boston Main Streets Foundation, the City of Boston, foundations) rather than across the nonprofit's own books. The Substation project, discussed in Section 4.5, is the cleanest illustration of that pattern at work.

4.5 Project Highlight: The Substation

The Roslindale Substation, located at 4228 Washington Street in the heart of the district, is the single most documented capital-stack vignette available for this case. The building is a 1911 Boston Elevated Railway substation, designed by Peabody and Stearns with Stone and Webster engineering, decommissioned in the 1970s, and listed on the National Register of Historic Places in August 2013. The adaptive reuse project, completed in 2018–2019, converted the substation into a brewery and event venue (anchored by Turtle Swamp Brewing) on the ground floor with co-working space below, and added 43 rental apartments in the adjacent Parkside on Adams development. The total project cost was approximately $15 million; the substation restoration alone was $4.8 million (Historic Boston Inc. n.d.; National Trust for Historic Preservation n.d.). The capital stack documented in publicly available sources includes $569,085 in Federal Historic Tax Credits, approximately $700,000 in Massachusetts state Historic Tax Credits, and the balance from private debt and equity assembled by the developer, Peregrine Group LLC. The historic preservation partner that originally assembled the deal was Historic Boston Inc.;

Roslindale Village Main Street's role was as community partner, convener, and corridor coordinator, not as the deal sponsor.

The Substation case is useful for two reasons. First, it shows the urban-variant capital stack at the project level: the federal and state historic tax credits together supplied roughly $1.3 million in equity-equivalent capital (because tax credits, once syndicated, function as equity in the capital stack), which made the $4.8 million substation restoration feasible. Second, and importantly for an economic development and housing finance course, the project directly illustrates the housing finance link. The 43 apartments at Parkside on Adams are exactly the kind of mixed-use product that ties a Main Street program to upstairs housing finance. The corridor's commercial vitality makes the upstairs apartments attractive to renters; the apartments' presence keeps the corridor populated outside business hours. The Main Street program is, indirectly, a housing program.

5. Lessons Learned

Five lessons emerge from examining Main Street America at the national, state, and local levels in these two cases. Each is a finding about how the model finances its work.

Capital stacking is the core financial role. The most generalizable lesson from both cases is that a local Main Street nonprofit's value to a downtown business or property owner is rarely a check from the Main Street nonprofit itself. It is the assembly of three or four small sources (a facade grant, a sign permit fee waiver, an SBA microloan referral, a tax credit application, a featured event slot) into a package that lets a marginal project pencil out. The Substation and the Welcome Center both illustrate this in different ways. Neither project's largest funder was the local Main Street nonprofit. In both cases, the Main Street nonprofit's contribution was the institutional vehicle and the coordination work that made the larger dollars usable. For practitioners, this means that replicating the Main Street model in a new context requires staffing the coordination function first, and worrying about a local capital base second.

The funding architecture above the local nonprofit shapes what it can do. Pennsylvania's three-layer architecture (state agency, state nonprofit affiliate, local implementing entity) provides funding that is slow but politically insulated. The $20 million Main Street Matters appropriation is locked in for FY24 through FY26 regardless of who wins the next gubernatorial election, and the Pennsylvania Downtown Center has held its coordinating role across multiple administrations. Boston's two-layer architecture (city department and city-affiliated foundation) provides faster decision-making and tighter integration with city planning and zoning, but is more sensitive to municipal budget cycles and mayoral priorities. Neither architecture is better in the abstract. They produce different mixes of speed, stability, and flexibility, and any new jurisdiction designing a Main Street program should deliberately choose among them.

Heritage-tourism economies and residential-corridor economies generate different funding mixes. Gettysburg can credibly tap NPS partnerships, hotel tax revenue (which flows to its DMO rather than to the Main Street nonprofit but supports the larger visitor economy), and the federal Historic Tax Credit, as its building stock and visitor base support these sources. Roslindale's stack leans more heavily on CDBG and on private sponsorship from regional businesses with no tourism nexus. The capital stack is partly a downstream effect of the local economy, not solely a policy choice. A practitioner looking to replicate Main Street in a new context needs to know which funding sources the local economy actually unlocks, not which sources are available in principle.

Equity tensions. Roslindale has gentrified meaningfully since 2010, and rising commercial rents have displaced some of the legacy small businesses the Main Street program originally aimed to protect. Gettysburg has the inverse problem: heritage-tourism revenue is concentrated in a few seasonal months, and second-home ownership is putting pressure on Adams County housing affordability for permanent residents. Main Street programs have responded to these tensions unevenly. The Shaw Main Streets program in Washington, DC, working with the District government, layered historic-district zoning protections with property-tax caps to “minimize the effects of gentrification” on long-time residents and businesses, an approach that is widely cited but not widely replicated (Main Street America 2018). Most local Main Street programs lack a comparable anti-displacement playbook. This is the most important unfinished work in the model.

Mixed-use is the bridge between Main Street and housing finance. The strongest projects in both cases are mixed-use buildings whose ground-floor commercial revenue helps underwrite the housing above them. The Roslindale Substation rehabilitation drew $1.3 million in federal and state historic tax credits and anchored the adjacent 43-unit Parkside on Adams rental development; the corridor's commercial vitality is what makes the apartments attractive to renters, and the apartments' presence is what keeps the corridor populated outside business hours. Main Street Gettysburg pursues an analogous logic through upper-story residential reactivation in heritage commercial buildings, aimed at keeping the downtown populated outside the seasonal tourist peak. The Main Street program is not only a small-business program. It is, indirectly, a housing program in both contexts, and the layered-finance tools it deploys (CDBG, HTC, philanthropy, private debt) are the same tools that finance affordable mixed-use development at a larger scale.

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Appendix

Table 1. Main Street America Funding Ecosystem by Tier and Type

Tier	**Public / Government Support**	**Philanthropic and Private Sources**	**Earned Income / Other**
National (Main Street America)	Federal grants and contracts (HUD, USDA, DOT pass-throughs)	Corporate sponsorships (American Express, Truist); foundation grants (Rockefeller, Kauffman)	Membership dues from designated communities; conference and event fees; Main Street Insurance Services revenue
State or City Coordinator	State legislative appropriations (e.g., Pennsylvania Main Street Matters $20M FY24-26; Virginia $2.1M FY26); CDBG pass-through; state historic tax credit administration	State-level private foundations and economic development partners (varies by state)	Local match fees from designated communities; program service contracts with state agencies
Local District (501(c)(3) or city department)	City general fund operating support; CDBG entitlement allocations; ARPA pass-throughs (sunset 2026); BID assessments; tax increment financing	Local business sponsorships; community foundation grants; family foundation grants; corporate gifts	Member dues; signature event revenue; vendor fees; fee-for-service contracts

Source: Main Street America 2025; Pennsylvania DCED 2024; Virginia LIS 2025.

Exhibit A. Main Street Gettysburg Capital Stack

Tier	**Source**	**Documented Amount**	**Type**	**Note**
State	PA Main Street Matters designation	Up to $225,000 per cycle	Grant eligibility	Per Main Street Matters program

State	PA DCED Keystone Community Grant	$50,000	Project grant	Funds Facade Improvement Program
State	PA Historic Preservation Tax Credit	Major (program-level)	Tax credit	$5M across 21 projects FY23–24 round
Federal	HUD Community Project Funding (Welcome Center)	$1,272,436	One-time appropriation	FY24 federal omnibus, March 2024
Federal	Federal Historic Tax Credit	Major (project-level)	Tax credit	Project-dependent on National Register buildings
Borough / County	Borough of Gettysburg in-kind support	Documented in-kind only	Operating	Staff time, infrastructure, local match
Borough / County	Borough of Gettysburg CIP (Welcome Center)	$300,000	Capital	FY2025 Capital Improvement Plan line
Borough / County	Adams County hotel tax	Minor (flows to DMO)	Tourism revenue	75% to Destination Gettysburg
Philanthropic	Adams County Community Foundation Forward Fund	$10,000 (operating)	Grant	Annual operating support
Philanthropic	Adams County Community Foundation (Welcome Center)	$40,000	Project grant	$20K Forward Fund + $20K Challenge Grant, 2023
Earned / Private	Business member dues	Minor	Recurring	Heritage-tourism business members
Earned / Private	Signature event revenue	Moderate	Annual	Christmas Festival, GettysFest, etc.
Earned / Private	Corporate sponsorships	Moderate	Annual	Heritage-tourism corporate partners

Methodology: documented dollar amounts cited where known. Where dollar amounts are not publicly documented, lines are labeled qualitatively (Major, Moderate, Minor) based on program literature. Main Street Gettysburg's annual Form 990 line-item breakdown was not available to this research; aggregate operating revenue is therefore described in tier terms rather than as a single dollar total.

Sources: Pennsylvania DCED 2024; Pennsylvania Historic Preservation 2024; Borough of Gettysburg 2024; Borough of Gettysburg n.d.a; Main Street Gettysburg 2025b; Gettysburg Connection n.d.b.

Exhibit B. Roslindale Village Main Street Capital Stack, FY2024

Total operating revenue (FY2024 Form 990): $456,673

Total expenses (FY2024 Form 990): $424,112
Net surplus (FY2024): $32,561
Pass-through grants made to district businesses (FY2024): $0 (down from $73,319 in FY2023)

Tier	Source	Documented or Tier Amount	Type	Note
Municipal	City of Boston Main Streets program (OEOI)	$1.5M annually program-level	Operating	Allocated across 20 districts; RVMS share is a fraction
Municipal	CDBG entitlement (Boston pass-through)	Major (programmatic)	Federal pass-through	Boston is a CDBG entitlement city
Municipal	ARPA pass-through (2021–2024)	Sunset by 2026	One-time	No longer active
Municipal	ReStore Boston facade grants	Project-level	Project grant	City-administered facade program
State	Massachusetts Downtown Initiative	None FY24–FY25	Grant	No Roslindale-specific award; pattern consistent with MDI's small-town focus
State	Massachusetts state Historic Tax Credit	Major (project-level)	Tax credit	Substation drew $700,000
Federal	Federal Historic Tax Credit	Major (project-level)	Tax credit	Substation drew $569,085
Federal	SBA microlending and 7(a) (via partner CDFIs)	Indirect	Credit	Through LISC Boston, BII, MCCI
Philanthropic	Boston Foundation, Hyams Foundation, Klarman Family Foundation	Moderate	Annual	Recurring philanthropic partners
Earned / Private	Corporate sponsorships ($5K+ "Rozzie Square" tier)	Moderate	Annual	Market Basket, Bain Capital, others
Earned / Private	Business member dues	Minor	Recurring	Roslindale Village businesses
Earned / Private	Signature event revenue	Major	Annual	Roslindale Open Studios, Spring Stroll, Wicked Local Beer Garden, weekly Farmers Market
Total revenue (FY2024)	All sources combined	$456,673		Per FY2024 Form 990, filed October 2025

Note: the FY2024 Form 990 reports total contributions and grants of $438,281 (96% of revenue), investment income of $16,017, and other revenue of $2,375. The contributions and grants line bundles all of the above public, philanthropic, and earned sources without disaggregating by source on the Form 990 itself. Tier and source attribution above is based on the funding-source descriptions in §4.4 and corroborating program literature, not on a line-item breakout in the 990.

Sources: ProPublica n.d.a (RVMS Form 990 FY2024); City of Boston 2015; Roslindale Village Main Street n.d.b; Historic Boston Inc. n.d.; National Trust for Historic Preservation n.d.

Exhibit C. Gettysburg Welcome Center: Documented Construction Funding

Year	**Source**	**Amount**	**Percent of Total**
2023	ACCF Forward Fund	$20,000	1.2%
2023	ACCF Challenge Grant	$20,000	1.2%
2024	HUD Community Project Funding (federal)	$1,272,436	78.9%
2025	Borough of Gettysburg Capital Improvement Plan	$300,000	18.6%
	Total documented construction funding	**$1,612,436**	100%

Completion target: 2026 (timed to America's 250th anniversary). Sequencing: ACCF philanthropic seed money (2023) led the federal earmark (2024), which led the borough capital plan (2025). Each stage made the next one possible.

Sources: Main Street Gettysburg 2025b; Borough of Gettysburg 2024.

Exhibit D. The Roslindale Substation: Documented Restoration Capital Stack

Source	**Amount**	**Percent of Restoration**
Federal Historic Tax Credit	$569,085	11.9%
Massachusetts state Historic Tax Credit (estimated)	$700,000	14.6%
Private debt and equity (residual, assembled by Peregrine Group LLC)	$3,530,915	73.6%
Total substation restoration cost	**$4,800,000**	100%

Combined HTC leverage (federal + state): approximately $1.3 million in equity-equivalent capital made the $4.8 million restoration feasible. The substation restoration anchored a larger $15 million mixed-use complex that included the adjacent Parkside on Adams development, which added 43 rental apartments. Completed 2018–2019.

Sources: Historic Boston Inc. n.d.; National Trust for Historic Preservation n.d.